¿QUÉ TIEMPO HACE?
EL TIEMPO

four verbs share the job — picking the wrong one is the whole difficulty

1. Which verb English uses *it is* for all of these; Spanish uses four different things

hace + noun
hace **frío**, hace **sol** · the weather *does* it

está + adjective
está **nublado** · the state of the sky right now

hay + noun
hay **niebla** · the thing is simply there

llueve, nieva
one word, no subject · the verb *is* the weather

There is no rule that predicts which group a word falls into — **learn the pair, not the word**. *hace viento* and *está nublado* and *hay niebla* all mean "it is …", and swapping the verbs gives you something no one says.

2. hacer + noun the biggest group, and the one with the trap

Hace **frío**. — it's cold
Hace **calor**. — it's hot
Hace **sol**. — it's sunny
Hace **viento**. — it's windy
Hace **fresco**. — it's chilly, pleasantly cool
Hace **buen** / **mal tiempo**. — the weather is nice / bad

Everything after *hace* is a noun, so it takes **mucho**, never *muy*:
Hace **mucho** frío. · Hace **mucho** calor. · Hace **mucho** viento.
~~hace muy frío~~ ~~hace muy calor~~

The giveaway: you can count it. *un poco de frío*, *demasiado calor* — all noun behaviour.

3. estar + adjective, and hay + noun the sky's state, and what is simply present

Está **nublado**. — it's cloudy
Está **despejado**. — it's clear
Está **lloviendo**. — it's raining, right now
Está **nevando**. — it's snowing, right now

Hay **niebla**. — it's foggy
Hay **tormenta**. — there's a storm
Hay **nubes**. — there are clouds
Hay **hielo**. — it's icy

The ones to unlearn, because English tempts you into them: ~~está ventoso~~ → **hace viento** · ~~está lluvioso~~ → **está lloviendo** or **llueve** · ~~está caluroso~~ → **hace calor**. *Está soleado* exists but Spain says **hace sol**.

4. The verbs with no subject third person singular, and nothing else, ever

llueve	it rains / it's raining	llover, o → ue · *va a llover* = it's going to rain
nieva	it snows / it's snowing	nevar, e → ie · *mañana va a nevar*
graniza	it's hailing	el granizo = hail
truena	it's thundering	el trueno = thunder · el relámpago = lightning

There is no *yo* for these. ~~yo llueve~~ is not a mistake you can make in English, which is exactly why it slips out.

5. Degrees, and tomorrow temperature has its own verb again

Estamos a veinticinco grados. — it's 25 degrees
¿**A cuántos grados estamos?** — what's the temperature?
Hace veinticinco grados. — also fine, with hacer
Estamos a cinco grados **bajo cero**. — -5 · sobre cero = above
La **máxima** es de 28. — the high · la mínima = the low

¿**Qué tiempo hace** hoy? — what's the weather like?
Va a llover. — it's going to rain
Hoy hace **más frío que** ayer. — colder than
En **primavera** · en **verano** · en **otoño** · en **invierno** — no article

6. Three ways to say "it's cold" and they are not interchangeable

Hace frío.
The **weather** is cold. Outside, in the world.

Tengo frío.
I **am** cold. A person *has* cold in Spanish — never *soy* or *estoy frío*.

Está frío.
The **thing** is cold. *Mi café está frío* — it wasn't always.

Weather is the clearest case in the language of a meaning that belongs to a **pair**, not a word. *Frío* alone tells you nothing: **hace** frío is the air, **tengo** frío is you, **está** frío is your coffee.